STIVEN CATALYST

FIRST SERIES · OCTOBER 2026

MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



OPERATIONS

GEMBA: MANAGEMENT WHERE THE WORK HAPPENS

Ohno's circle on the floor, what staff notice of leaders' walks, Womack's purpose, process and people, a randomised study of walking around, Mann's four questions, and a card for your own walk.

49% of the staff surveyed in 44 neonatal intensive care units were not sure whether leadership walkrounds took place at all.

SEXTON ET AL., 2014

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NO. 40 · OPERATIONS

In this issue

A report says what happened. It rarely says how. The how is found where the work is done, the gemba. We follow a manager there: what to look for, what to ask, and what to do afterwards.

Taiichi Ohno made his students stand in a circle on the shop floor and watch. Jim Womack turned the habit into a walk along a whole value stream, with three questions. In 44 neonatal units, almost half the staff were not sure whether their leaders walked at all. In a randomised study in US hospitals, walking around on average made things worse, unless the problems it found were solved. David Mann's four questions show what to ask on the way.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editor interprets rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

Stand in the circle

According to Teruyuki Minoura, one of his students who later headed Toyota's manufacturing in North America, Taiichi Ohno would take his students to a problem area and draw a circle on the floor, where they were to observe, think and analyse.

“He wanted us to watch and ask ‘why’ over and over again.”

01

Gemba

“actual place”: where value is created, a shop floor, a ward, a kitchen, a loading ramp

02

Genchi genbutsu

real place, real thing: go and see the facts for yourself

03

Gemba walk

grasping the situation by watching and asking, before taking action

OUR READING

The circle asks you to look long enough to stop seeing what you expected to see.

Sources: John Teresko, IndustryWeek, 2004; Lean Enterprise Institute, 2014

The circle is known from the accounts of Ohno's students; how long they stood in it varies from one telling to another, so we give no figure. The three terms follow the Lean Enterprise Institute's lexicon.

THE NUMBERS

Who notices the walk

In leadership walkrounds, senior leaders visit frontline staff to talk about safety. J. Bryan Sexton and colleagues asked staff in 44 US neonatal intensive care units about them; 2,073 of 3,294 answered (62.9%).

STAFF IN 44 NEONATAL INTENSIVE CARE UNITS, 2011



Units where more staff heard back about what the walkrounds had changed rated their safety culture better and tended to report less burnout. In the adult clinical areas used for comparison, 27.6% had taken part.

OUR READING

A walk the team never hears about again is, for the team, a walk that did not happen.

Source: J. Bryan Sexton et al., BMJ Quality & Safety, 2014

Participation and feedback are averages of the units; 49.1% is the share of all who answered. Because the survey captures a single point in time, it shows an association and cannot establish cause.

THE MODEL

Purpose, process, people

Jim Womack, founder of the Lean Enterprise Institute, collected a decade of his walks in Gemba Walks (2011). Value flows across a company, he argues, while the company is organised in vertical departments. So walk one value stream from end to end, together with everyone who touches it.

01
Purpose
What problem does this process solve for the customer?

02
Process
How does it actually work, step by step?

03
People
Are they engaged in creating, sustaining and improving it?

In the foreword to the book, John Shook recalls how Toyota's chairman Fujio Cho summed up what lean leaders do: go see, ask why, show respect. Womack himself told an audience in 2011 that value is always created at the bottom.

OUR READING

On your own you see one department. Walk the stream with everyone who touches it, and you see the points where work passes from one department to the next, which is where problems tend to wait.

Sources: James P. Womack, Lean Enterprise Institute, 2011 (via Lean Enterprise Institute, press release and excerpt); Jill Jusko, IndustryWeek, 2011; Lean Enterprise Institute, 2014

The three questions follow the Lean Enterprise Institute's lexicon; Cho's words are quoted by Shook. The interpretation is ours.

More in the essay KPIs do not improve in Excel

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

When walking makes it worse

Anita Tucker and Sara Singer tested management by walking around in US hospitals chosen at random. For 18 months, senior managers observed frontline work, asked for ideas and worked with staff on the problems. 56 work areas took part; 138 in control hospitals did not.

PROBLEMS PER WORK AREA, ON AVERAGE



On average the programme lowered the staff's rating of improvement compared with the control areas. It worked better where teams took on problems they could solve within 30 days, and where a senior manager was made responsible for seeing a problem resolved. In some of the areas that fell furthest, the time went into ranking problems, and none were solved.

OUR READING

Being seen on the floor earns nothing by itself. A walk pays off only when what it finds gets fixed.

Source: Anita L. Tucker & Sara J. Singer, Production and Operations Management, 2015 (via Harvard Business School, Working Paper 12-113, 2013)

Improvement was rated by nurses on a 1–5 scale, before (2004) and after (2006). The counts per work area come from the 2013 working paper; the published article (2015) reports the same design and findings.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Four questions, one count

David Mann, who wrote Creating a Lean Culture, treats the gemba walk as a repeatable part of a leader's standard work, not a box-checking exercise. He suggests opening with: “I'm really here as a student, and you all are the teachers.” Then four questions:

1. **What's the process here?**
   Ask people to show you how it is done.
2. **How can you tell it's working?**
   A board, a count or a signal you can see from where you stand.
3. **What do you do when it's not working?**
   Listen for whether there is a proper way to raise it, or only a workaround.
4. **Is there work going on to improve it?**
   Ask for the last change and who proposed it.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A MONTH OF WALKS IN A DISPATCH AREA

Walks	8 planned, 7 held
Problems	14 found, 9 closed within 30 days
Feedback	the team was told about 4 of the 9

The gap sits in the last line: the fixes happened, but the team barely heard of them. All figures are made up.

Sources: Mark Graban, Lean Blog Podcast #212, 2014; David Mann, Productivity Press, 2005 (via Routledge contents, 3rd ed., 2015; Lean Blog interview, 2014); Anita L. Tucker & Sara J. Singer, Production and Operations Management, 2015 (via Harvard Business School, Working Paper 12-113, 2013); J. Bryan Sexton et al., BMJ Quality & Safety, 2014

The questions and the opening line are Mann's, from a 2014 interview; the hints under them and the example are the editors'. Counting what is closed and told back follows Tucker & Singer and Sexton et al.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The gemba walk card

One walk, one process. Write down what you saw and leave out who did it; before you leave, set the date when you will come back with an answer.

01 Process and place which value stream, where it starts and ends

02 Purpose what problem it solves for the customer

03 What I saw facts and places, not opinions or names

04 What they do when it fails in the words of the people who do the work

05 Problems I take with me which can be solved within 30 days; who owns each one

06 Told back when and how the team hears what changed

Sources: Lean Enterprise Institute, 2014; Mark Graban, Lean Blog Podcast #212, 2014; Anita L. Tucker & Sara J. Singer, Production and Operations Management, 2015 (via Harvard Business School, Working Paper 12-113, 2013)

The editors' proposal, after Womack's three questions, Mann's questions and the findings of Tucker & Singer.

Open the tool: 5 Whys stivencatalyst.com/tools/five-whys/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Step Inside the Circle
John Teresko, IndustryWeek, 2004
https://www.industryweek.com/leadership/companies-executives/article/21942244/step-inside-the-circle

Lean Lexicon: gemba; gemba walk
Lean Enterprise Institute, 2014
https://www.lean.org/lexicon-terms/gemba-walk/

Exposure to Leadership WalkRounds in neonatal intensive care units is associated with a better patient safety culture and less caregiver burnout
J. Bryan Sexton et al., BMJ Quality & Safety, 2014
https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC4167964/

Gemba Walks
James P. Womack, Lean Enterprise Institute, 2011 · via Lean Enterprise Institute, press release and excerpt
https://www.lean.org/about-lei/press-releases/lean-management-book-gemba-walks-by-james-womack-challenges-the-prevailing-management-system/

Taking the Gemba Walk
Jill Jusko, IndustryWeek, 2011
https://www.industryweek.com/operations/continuous-improvement/article/21961267/taking-the-gemba-walk

The Effectiveness of Management-By-Walking-Around: A Randomized Field Study
Anita L. Tucker & Sara J. Singer, Production and Operations Management, 2015 · via Harvard Business School, Working Paper 12-113, 2013
https://doi.org/10.1111/poms.12226

Creating a Lean Culture: David Mann on Leader Standard Work and Lean Management Systems
Mark Graban, Lean Blog Podcast #212, 2014
https://www.leanblog.org/2014/12/podcast-212-david-mann-creating-a-lean-culture-3rd-ed/

Creating a Lean Culture: Tools to Sustain Lean Conversions
David Mann, Productivity Press, 2005 · via Routledge contents, 3rd ed., 2015; Lean Blog interview, 2014

CORRECTION · 12 OCTOBER 2026

The survey of staff in 44 neonatal intensive care units is now dated 2011, when it was carried out; the chart first gave 2014, the year the study was published.

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what it measures, in the full text where it could be opened. A source read only in a summary, an abstract or excerpts is marked “via”. A figure not confirmed in what was read is marked so on its page, or left out. The editor's interpretation is marked “Our reading”.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

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Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

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Management Review · No. 40 · October 2026 · Stiven Catalyst
Edited by Stiven Janaqi, who answers for it; “the editors” in this publication means him. Its texts, translations, layout and the checking of figures against their sources are done in working sessions with Claude, an AI model by Anthropic.
stivencatalyst.com/how-this-is-made.html